

Glorious ruins

The spectacular Husuni Kubwa, or "Great Palace," was only used for a short time; it is not known why the sultan abandoned it. The site is now in ruins, but archaeological investigations here have revealed huge amounts of information about Swahili trade and lifestyle. The finds tell of a melting pot of African, Asian, and Arabian cultures.

1 Mangroves now spread out around the site. Once, these would have been managed, leaving a wide waterway leading to the palace.

2 Harvested from offshore reefs, coral stone was used for roofs and wall friezes. It is scattered on the ground where roofs have collapsed.

Pool view

This grand open-air pool was the sultan's private bathtub. Here he had an incredible view out to sea. This was practical, too, as he could watch ships arriving while he washed.



3 The sultan and his family lived in a series of private rooms clustered around a number of interior courtyards. No visitors came to this part of the palace.

4 In this large, open courtyard, goods were collected and traded. Banter and bartering in many different languages echoed around the high walls.

